

How We Did It

The methodology used to prepare the **BT Upstarts: India's Coolest Start-ups 2023** list
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BUSINESS TODAY'S HUNT for India's Coolest Start-ups began with a robust application process. A detailed form was circulated on our social media platforms and in our circles, attracting more than 90 submissions from various start-ups. Only start-ups incorporated between January 1, 2014, and December 31, 2021 were eligible to apply. Additionally, subsidiaries were explicitly excluded from consideration.

The editorial team then meticulously reviewed each application, applying the stipulated criteria to shortlist contenders. The screening process resulted in a curated list of 77 start-ups, that included those who organically applied and others recommended by the editorial team.

This list of 77 start-ups was then presented to a jury comprising industry veterans and experts. The jury had K. Ganesh, a seasoned serial entrepreneur and Promoter of bigbasket, Bluestone and Portea Medical; Padmaja Ruparel, President of the Indian Angel Network; Sidharth Pai, Founding Partner at zone4 Capital; Anas Rehman Junaid, Founder and MD of Hurun India; and Srinivas Rao Mahankali, CEO of T-Hub.

The jury engaged in a thorough review of the start-ups, providing their valuable insights and suggestions. Six start-ups—Darwinbox, Groww, Acko, Skyroot, Addverb, and boAt—earned unanimous approval,

receiving votes from all five jury members. Nineteen additional start-ups secured their place on the list with a majority vote in the initial round, demonstrating widespread jury endorsement. After the end of the initial round of selection, we had 25 confirmed names. At a subsequent stage, the remaining—comprising two 'yes' votes from the initial screening and additional suggestions from the jury—formed a pool of 22 more names. From this pool, the jury finalised the remaining 10 start-ups, each receiving a unanimous 'yes' from all five members. The final outcome was a comprehensive list of 35 start-ups, a culmination of meticulous evaluations, ensuring representation on the list. In cases where jury members held a financial interest or investment in any of the featured start-ups, such affiliations were officially disclosed before the selection process.

This multi-stage methodology, involving a stringent application process, detailed screening, and thorough jury deliberations, aimed to showcase the most innovative and promising start-ups in India. The inclusion of expert insights from the jury ensured a well-rounded selection, highlighting businesses with the ability to shape the future of the Indian entrepreneurial landscape. **BT**

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